Section 1: The Twin Pillars of Faith — Why Ṣalāh and Zakāh are Paired

Assalāmu ʿalaykum, Grade 7!

Throughout the Noble Qurʾān, whenever Allah describes true, complete believers, He almost always pairs two specific acts together: **establishing prayer (ṣalāh)** and **giving charity (zakāh)**.

In **Sūrah Ibrāhīm (14:31)**, Allah commands:

"Say to My believing servants that they should establish the prayer and spend out of that which We have given them, secretly and openly, before the coming of the Day in which there shall be no trade, nor mutual befriending."

The Vertical and Horizontal Dimensions of Faith

Why are these two acts inseparable?

- **Ṣalāh builds our vertical relationship**—our direct, spiritual connection of humility, gratitude, and obedience to our Creator.
- **Zakāh builds our horizontal relationship**—our moral responsibility, empathy, and generosity toward our fellow human beings.

Faith in Islam cannot remain purely personal or private. A person cannot claim to love Allah while ignoring the suffering of His creation. Beyond character building, charity produces tangible, physical benefits in this world. Prophet Muḥammad (s.a.w.) taught:

"Give charity, and cure your sick ones through the giving of charity. Surely, charity repels accidents and illnesses, and is a source of increasing your lifespan and good deeds."

Section 2: What Does Zakāh Really Mean? (Purification & The Pruning Analogy)

In everyday conversation, people often think zakāh simply means "giving money." However, in original Arabic, **the literal meaning of zakāh is "purification"**.

Historically, the word was used to describe the **healthy growth and nurturing of a tree or plant in the best possible way**.

THE PRUNING ANALOGY OF ZAKĀH	
Pruning a Fruit Tree	Giving Zakāh from Wealth
• Cutting away selective branches • Looks like a physical reduction • Directs nutrients to main trunk • Yields larger, healthier fruit	• Giving away a portion of wealth • Appears to reduce bank balance • Cleanses remaining resources • Causes wealth to grow in purity

When a gardener prunes a fruit tree by cutting away certain branches, it might look to an observer like the tree is being damaged or reduced. But that pruning is precisely what allows the remaining tree to flourish and bear sweet, abundant fruit. In the same way, when we give away a portion of our wealth for Allah's sake, **it cleanses the remaining wealth that stays with us, allowing it to grow in a pure and blessed manner**.

Three Descriptions of Charity in the Qurʾān

The Noble Qurʾān uses three distinct financial metaphors to describe the act of giving:

1. **A Means of Purification (Tahārah)** In **Sūrah at-Tawbah (9:103)**, Allah instructs the Prophet:

"Take, from their possessions, (some) charity to cleanse them and purify them thereby…" *Giving charity washes away the spiritual dirt of greed, hoarding, and selfishness from the human heart.*

1. **A Good Loan to Allah (Qarḍ Ḥasan)** In **Sūrah al-Ḥadīd (57:11)**, Allah asks:

"Who is there who will offer Allah a good loan so that He will multiply it for them; and they will have an excellent reward?" *Even though Allah is the ultimate Owner of everything in existence, He humbly describes our spending for His creation as a "loan" to Him—and promises to repay it multiplied many times over.*

1. **An Unbeatable Investment / Transaction (Tijārah)** In **Sūrah aṣ-Ṣaff (61:10–11)**, Allah says:

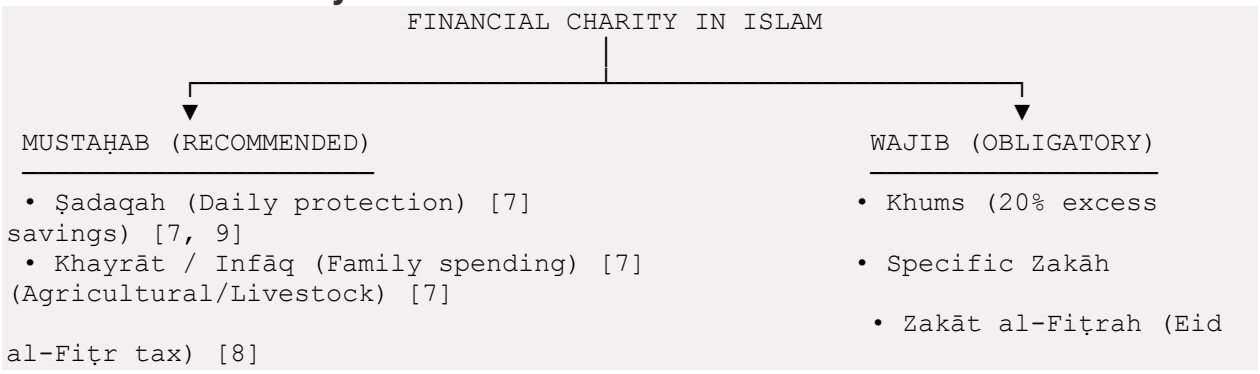
"O you who believe! Shall I guide you to a transaction (deal) that will save you from a painful punishment? Have faith in Allah and His Messenger, and strive in the way of Allah with your wealth and your selves…"
When people invest in worldly stock markets or commercial banks, there is always a risk of market crashes, inflation, or complete loss. However, **investing with Allah guarantees a massive profit in both worlds with zero risk of loss**.

Section 3: Broadening Our Horizons — Forms & Types of Charity
Charity in Islam is not restricted to those with large bank accounts. It is divided into **non-financial** and **financial** categories.
1. Non-Financial Forms of Charity

- **Time & Effort**: Dedicating your physical energy or time to help someone complete a difficult task.
- **Education & Skills**: Using your personal talents, academic knowledge, or technical skills to tutor others or teach them a trade.
- **Kindness & Emotional Support**: Patiently listening to someone in distress and comforting them with kind, encouraging words.
- **Repelling Harm**: Clearing obstacles or hazards from a public path.

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2. Financial Charity Classifications



(Conditional promises) [8]
- Nadhr / ʿAhd
- Qasam (Sworn oaths) [8]
- Kaffārah (Penalties for missed fasts) [8, 9]

Deep-Dive into Khums (The One-Fifth Duty)

While general Zakāh applies to specific agricultural and monetary conditions, **Khums is the most common obligatory fiscal duty for believers today**.

- **Definition**: Khums literally means "**one-fifth**". It requires paying **20% of one's excess yearly savings** at the end of a personal financial year.
- **What is Included**: It applies to money remaining after ordinary living expenses have been met throughout the year, as well as gifts or items that remained unused for a full year.
- **Qurʾānic Foundation**: In **Sūrah al-Anfāl (8:41)**, Allah states:

"And know that whatever of a thing you acquire, a fifth of it is for Allah, and for the Messenger, and for (his) near relatives, and the orphans, and the needy, and the wayfarer…"

- **Distribution**: The calculated 20% is paid toward causes approved by one's Marjaʿ (religious authority) to support the needy, Islamic education, and community development.

Other Obligatory Financial Duties

- **Zakāt al-Fiṭrah**: An obligatory charity paid on the day of Eid al-Fiṭr by the family breadwinner for themselves and all dependents.
- **Kaffārah**: A monetary penalty used to feed the poor when a person breaks an oath, violates specific Ḥajj rules, or misses/breaks fasts during the Holy Month of Ramaḍān without a valid excuse.

Section 4: The Highest Spiritual Rewards — Serving Believers & Repelling Harm

1. Meeting the Needs of Fellow Believers

Islam places an extraordinary premium on using our resources, time, or social standing to fulfill the needs of a fellow Muslim brother or sister.

During a Ḥajj pilgrimage, **Imām Jaʿfar aṣ-Ṣādiq (a.s.)** explained the enormous rewards for each rite of Ḥajj to a companion. When the companion expressed awe at these rewards, the Imām asked:

"Do you want me to teach you something that brings even greater rewards than these?" *The companion asked if such an act existed. Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq (a.s.) replied:* "Yes, fulfilling the need of a believer is better than (performing) one Ḥajj, and another Ḥajj, and another Ḥajj…"—*until he counted* **10 optional Ḥajj pilgrimages!**

Similarly, **Prophet Muḥammad (s.a.w.)** compared helping a believer to iʿtikāf (secluding oneself in a masjid for intense worship for at least 3 consecutive days):

"Walking with a fellow believer to help them in their need is dearer to Allah than performing iʿtikāf in Masjid Al-Ḥarām (in Mecca) for two months."

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2. Bringing Benefit and Repelling Harm

THE SPECTRUM OF REPELLING HARM
LEVEL 1: EVERYDAY ACTION • Picking up trash, glass, or obstacles from a public sidewalk [13] • Hadith: Fulfills every Muslim's daily obligation of charity [13]
LEVEL 2: ADVANCED / PROFESSIONAL EXCELLENCE • Researching diseases to discover medical cures or vaccines [13] • Engineering infrastructure to mitigate natural floods and fires [13] • Hadith: "Whoever repels from the Muslim community a flood or a fire, Paradise becomes obligatory for them." [14]

1. **Daily Charity for Everyone**: Prophet Muḥammad (s.a.w.) once declared: "Charity is obligatory upon all Muslims every day." When the companions asked who could possibly afford to give money every single day, the Prophet replied: **"Even removing harm from the path of believers is charity."**
2. **Bringing Benefit to Allah's Dependents**: Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq (a.s.) quoted the Messenger of Allah (s.a.w.):

"The creations are the dependents of Allah. The most beloved (of the servants of Allah) are those who bring the most benefit to them, and who help them in their needs."

1. **Advanced Science & Structural Safety as Highest Charity**: This concept extends to professional fields like medicine, civil engineering, and environmental science. Developing a cure for a disease or engineering flood defenses to save human lives is a major form of charity. Imām as-Sajjād (a.s.) narrated from Imām Ḥusayn (a.s.) that the Prophet (s.a.w.) said:

"Whoever repels from the Muslim community a flood or a fire, Paradise becomes obligatory for them."

Section 5: Classroom Review & Critical Reflection

To wrap up today's lecture, reflect on these four review prompts in your study journals:

1. **The Pruning Concept**: How does the linguistic root of zakāh (purification and growth through pruning) challenge the misconception that charity reduces wealth?
2. **Investment Analysis**: Why is offering a "good loan" to Allah described as a transaction superior to any worldly stock market or commercial bank?
3. **Calculating Khums**: What percentage is paid for Khums, what items does it apply to at the end of a financial year, and which Qurʾānic verse mandates it?
4. **Comparing Rewards**: Why did Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq (a.s.) rate helping a fellow believer higher than 10 optional Ḥajj trips?